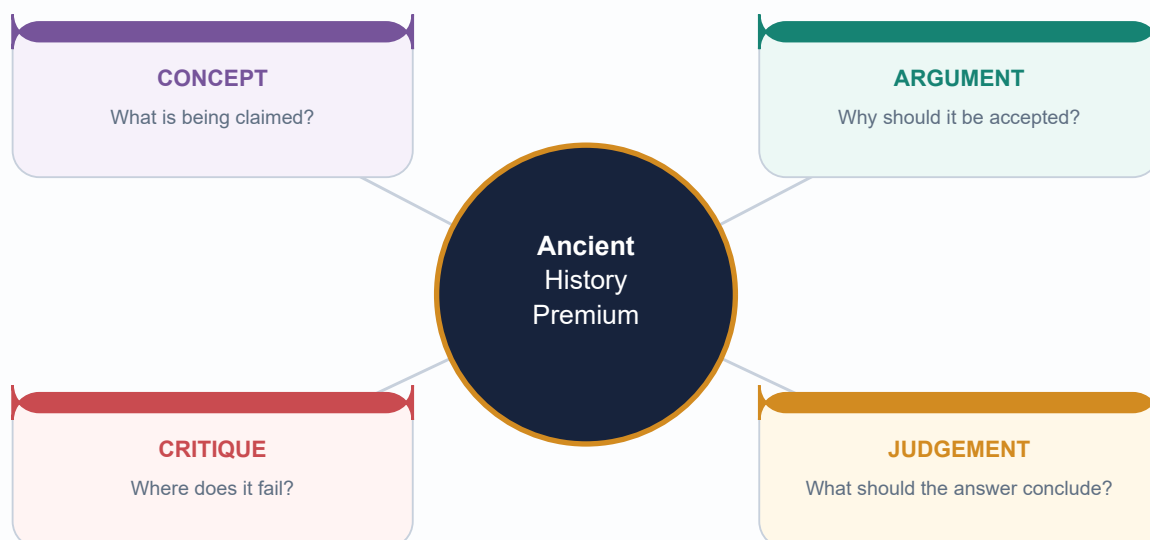


SOLVED WORKBOOK | GENERATED - APPROVAL PENDING

Ancient History 16 - Premium Solved Practice Workbook

Central Asian Contacts: Indo-Greeks, Shakas, Pahlavas and Kushanas
3 verified/routed PYQs | 48 hard MCQs | 12 remedials | 9 full solved Mains
Strict answer rotation A -> B -> C -> D | inferred keys explicitly marked



Facts from official sources | Inferences clearly marked | No fabricated data

HIGH UPSC RELEVANCE

HIGH

PYQ 01 - 2019 GS-I Mains Q1: Gandhara elements

PYQ Ancient
History

NEWS TRIGGER

Verified/routed UPSC demand with source and key status stated explicitly.

STATIC THEORY

- STATUS: Official printed question verified from the locally held UPSC Mains paper.
- QUESTION: Highlight the Central Asian and Greco-Bactrian elements in the Gandhara art. (10 marks, 150 words)
- MODEL SOLUTION: Gandhara art was a Buddhist programme created in north-western workshops where Greco-Bactrian visual conventions met Central Asian political and social contexts. Greco-Bactrian/Hellenistic elements are visible in anatomically modelled bodies, wavy hair, naturalistic faces and heavy, pleated drapery; schist and later stucco supported this modelling. Central Asian elements operated especially through Kushana patronage, frontier costume such as tunics and boots, mobile artisans and the route environment linking Bactria, Gandhara and northern India. The Kanishka-associated reliquary from Shah-j-i-ki-dheri and the wider Kushana monastic landscape show the patronage mechanism. Yet the subjects-Buddha, bodhisattvas, Jatakas and Buddhist ritual-remained rooted in Buddhist iconography, while Mathura provides an indigenous red-sandstone control. Gandhara was therefore layered Buddhist art in a Hellenised idiom, not imported Greek art.
- WHY THIS EARNS MARKS: It obeys 'highlight', separates the two named external strands, uses material and patronage evidence, identifies the Indian Buddhist core and adds a Mathura qualification.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Exact demand is answered before adjacent background.
2. Named evidence is interpreted and qualified.

UPSC TRAPS

- WRONG:** Treating an inferred key as official.
- CORRECT:** Key status is prominently labelled.

MAINS ANGLE

It obeys 'highlight', separates the two named external strands, uses material and patronage evidence, identifies the Indian Buddhist core and adds a Mathura qualification.

STUDY LINK

Topic 16 solved PYQ bank.

HIGH

PYQ 02 - 2020 Prelims GS-I Q22: Mahayana schools

PYQ Ancient
History

NEWS TRIGGER

Verified/routed UPSC demand with source and key status stated explicitly.

STATIC THEORY

- STATUS: Official question verified locally; official key unavailable locally. INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED.

- QUESTION: Statements: (1) Sthaviravadins belong to Mahayana Buddhism; (2) Lokottaravadin was an offshoot of Mahasanghika; (3) Deification of Buddha by Mahasanghikas fostered Mahayana. Which are correct?

- A. 1 and 2 only

- B. 2 and 3 only

- C. 3 only

- D. 1, 2 and 3

- ANSWER: B

- MODEL SOLUTION: Statement 1 is incorrect: Sthaviravada belongs to the early Buddhist school traditions and cannot be placed inside Mahayana. Statement 2 is correct: Lokottaravada developed within the Mahasanghika stream. Statement 3 is accepted in the question's doctrinal-history framing: Mahasanghika exaltation of the Buddha helped create an intellectual environment favourable to Mahayana. Hence 2 and 3 only.

- WHY THIS EARNS MARKS: It distinguishes early schools from later Mahayana and avoids making Kanishka the originator of Mahayana.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Exact demand is answered before adjacent background.
2. Named evidence is interpreted and qualified.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Treating an inferred key as official.

CORRECT: Key status is prominently labelled.

MAINS ANGLE

It distinguishes early schools from later Mahayana and avoids making Kanishka the originator of Mahayana.

STUDY LINK

Topic 16 solved PYQ bank.

HIGH**PYQ 03 - 2023 Prelims GS-I Q46: Milinda-panha attribution**

PYQ Ancient History

NEWS TRIGGER

Verified/routed UPSC demand with source and key status stated explicitly.

STATIC THEORY

- STATUS: Official question verified locally; official key unavailable locally. INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED.

- QUESTION: Pairs included Devichandragupta-Bilhana, Hammira-Mahakavya-Nayachandra Suri, Milinda-panha-Nagarjuna and Nitivakyamrita-Somadeva Suri. How many are correctly matched?

- A. Only one
- B. Only two
- C. Only three
- D. All four

- ANSWER: B

- MODEL SOLUTION: Devichandraguptam is associated with Vishakhadatta, so pair 1 is wrong. Hammira-Mahakavya is associated with Nayachandra Suri, so pair 2 is correct. Milinda-panha centres on the dialogue between Milinda and Nagasena, not authorship by Nagarjuna, so pair 3 is wrong. Nitivakyamrita is associated with Somadeva Suri, so pair 4 is correct. Two pairs are correct.

- WHY THIS EARNS MARKS: It catches the Nagasena-Nagarjuna trap and treats Milindapanho as dialogic Buddhist literature.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Exact demand is answered before adjacent background.
2. Named evidence is interpreted and qualified.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Treating an inferred key as official.

CORRECT: Key status is prominently labelled.

MAINS ANGLE

It catches the Nagasena-Nagarjuna trap and treats Milindapanho as dialogic Buddhist literature.

STUDY LINK

Topic 16 solved PYQ bank.

HIGH**Hard MCQ 01**Prelims Ancient
History**STATIC THEORY**

- QUESTION: Which sequence best preserves group distinctions?

- A. Indo-Greek -> Shaka -> Pahlava -> Kushana, with regional overlap
- B. Greek -> Kushana -> Maurya -> Shaka
- C. Shaka and Pahlava as one dynasty
- D. All four as branches of the Yuezhi

- CORRECT ANSWER: A - Indo-Greek -> Shaka -> Pahlava -> Kushana, with regional overlap

- NAMED EVIDENCE/CONCEPT: Terminology and overlap

- EXPLANATION: Prevents collapse of separate polities

- QUALIFICATION: Sequence is broad, not universal in every region

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Indo-Greek -> Shaka -> Pahlava -> Kushana, with regional overlap
2. Terminology and overlap

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choosing by ruler-name familiarity.
CORRECT: Match group, source, region and chronology.

MAINS ANGLE

Prevents collapse of separate polities; limit the claim because sequence is broad, not universal in every region.

STUDY LINK

Topic 16 hard practice.

HIGH**Hard MCQ 02**Prelims Ancient
History**STATIC THEORY**

- QUESTION: Which source is most decisive for attributable Indo-Greek rulers?
- A. Puranic king lists alone
- B. Portrait coins with royal names and bilingual legends
- C. Sangam poems
- D. Ashokan pillar edicts
- CORRECT ANSWER: B - Portrait coins with royal names and bilingual legends
- NAMED EVIDENCE/CONCEPT: Indo-Greek coinage
- EXPLANATION: Names rulers and political communication
- QUALIFICATION: Distribution is not an exact frontier

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Portrait coins with royal names and bilingual legends
2. Indo-Greek coinage

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choosing by ruler-name familiarity.
CORRECT: Match group, source, region and chronology.

MAINS ANGLE

Names rulers and political communication; limit the claim because distribution is not an exact frontier.

STUDY LINK

Topic 16 hard practice.

HIGH**Hard MCQ 03**Prelims Ancient
History

STATIC THEORY

- QUESTION: Demetrius is important because he is associated with:
- A. Founding the Shaka era
- B. The Junagadh repair
- C. An early Bactrian Greek crossing south of the Hindu Kush
- D. Unifying the Great Yuezhi
- CORRECT ANSWER: C - An early Bactrian Greek crossing south of the Hindu Kush
- NAMED EVIDENCE/CONCEPT: Demetrius coin sequence
- EXPLANATION: Marks Indo-Greek formation
- QUALIFICATION: Campaign extent is reconstructed

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. An early Bactrian Greek crossing south of the Hindu Kush
2. Demetrius coin sequence

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choosing by ruler-name familiarity.

CORRECT: Match group, source, region and chronology.

MAINS ANGLE

Marks Indo-Greek formation; limit the claim because campaign extent is reconstructed.

STUDY LINK

Topic 16 hard practice.

HIGH**Hard MCQ 04**Prelims Ancient
History**STATIC THEORY**

- QUESTION: The safest reading of Menander is:
- A. A Kushana founder
- B. A Kardamaka satrap
- C. The author of Milindapanho
- D. A coin-rich Indo-Greek ruler remembered as Milinda in Buddhist dialogue literature
- CORRECT ANSWER: D - A coin-rich Indo-Greek ruler remembered as Milinda in Buddhist dialogue literature
- NAMED EVIDENCE/CONCEPT: Coins plus Milindapanho
- EXPLANATION: Combines political and intellectual evidence
- QUALIFICATION: Dialogue is not a transcript

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. A coin-rich Indo-Greek ruler remembered as Milinda in Buddhist dialogue literature
2. Coins plus Milindapanho

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Choosing by ruler-name familiarity.**CORRECT:** Match group, source, region and chronology.**MAINS ANGLE**

Combines political and intellectual evidence; limit the claim because dialogue is not a transcript.

STUDY LINK

Topic 16 hard practice.

HIGH**Hard MCQ 05**Prelims Ancient
History**STATIC THEORY**

- QUESTION: Milindapanho is best classified as:
- A. Dialogic Buddhist literature with historical value and genre limits
- B. An official court diary
- C. A coin catalogue
- D. A Greek embassy report
- CORRECT ANSWER: A - Dialogic Buddhist literature with historical value and genre limits
- NAMED EVIDENCE/CONCEPT: Milinda-Nagasena dialogue
- EXPLANATION: Illuminates Buddhist reasoning
- QUALIFICATION: Composite literary history

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Dialogic Buddhist literature with historical value and genre limits
2. Milinda-Nagasena dialogue

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Choosing by ruler-name familiarity.**CORRECT:** Match group, source, region and chronology.**MAINS ANGLE**

Illuminates Buddhist reasoning; limit the claim because composite literary history.

STUDY LINK

Topic 16 hard practice.

HIGH**Hard MCQ 06**Prelims Ancient
History

STATIC THEORY

- QUESTION: The Heliodorus pillar directly records:
- A. Menander founding a monastery
- B. An ambassador of Antialcidas dedicating a garuda pillar to Vasudeva
- C. Rudradaman repairing a lake
- D. Kanishka founding an era
- CORRECT ANSWER: B - An ambassador of Antialcidas dedicating a garuda pillar to Vasudeva
- NAMED EVIDENCE/CONCEPT: Besnagar inscription
- EXPLANATION: Diplomacy and Bhagavata affiliation
- QUALIFICATION: One individual is not a population

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. An ambassador of Antialcidas dedicating a garuda pillar to Vasudeva
2. Besnagar inscription

UPSC TRAPS

- WRONG:** Choosing by ruler-name familiarity.
- CORRECT:** Match group, source, region and chronology.

MAINS ANGLE

Diplomacy and Bhagavata affiliation; limit the claim because one individual is not a population.

STUDY LINK

Topic 16 hard practice.

HIGH**Hard MCQ 07**Prelims Ancient
History**STATIC THEORY**

- QUESTION: Agathocles' coin series is significant for:
- A. The first Junagadh Sanskrit prashasti
- B. Kushana divine kingship
- C. Early datable Balarama-Vasudeva imagery with bilingual legends
- D. A Sasanian conquest
- CORRECT ANSWER: C - Early datable Balarama-Vasudeva imagery with bilingual legends
- NAMED EVIDENCE/CONCEPT: Agathocles coins
- EXPLANATION: Royal recognition of Indian cults
- QUALIFICATION: Does not prove private conversion

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Early datable Balarama-Vasudeva imagery with bilingual legends
2. Agathocles coins

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Choosing by ruler-name familiarity.**CORRECT:** Match group, source, region and chronology.**MAINS ANGLE**

Royal recognition of Indian cults; limit the claim because does not prove private conversion.

STUDY LINK

Topic 16 hard practice.

HIGH**Hard MCQ 08**

Prelims Ancient History

STATIC THEORY

- QUESTION: Which statement about Indo-Greek chronology is strongest?
- A. One unified dynasty ruled all north India
- B. Every ruler has exact literary dates
- C. Indo-Greek rule ended everywhere simultaneously
- D. Several rulers and lines were concurrent and remain coin-reconstructed
- CORRECT ANSWER: D - Several rulers and lines were concurrent and remain coin-reconstructed
- NAMED EVIDENCE/CONCEPT: Numismatic sequence
- EXPLANATION: Explains overlap
- QUALIFICATION: Chronology remains revisable

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Several rulers and lines were concurrent and remain coin-reconstructed
2. Numismatic sequence

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Choosing by ruler-name familiarity.**CORRECT:** Match group, source, region and chronology.**MAINS ANGLE**

Explains overlap; limit the claim because chronology remains revisable.

STUDY LINK

Topic 16 hard practice.

HIGH**Hard MCQ 09**

Prelims Ancient History

STATIC THEORY

- QUESTION: Maues/Moga is associated with:
- A. Early Shaka authority in the Taxila-Gandhara region
- B. Kushana Mathura sculpture
- C. Mauryan Pataliputra
- D. Gupta Udayagiri
- CORRECT ANSWER: A - Early Shaka authority in the Taxila-Gandhara region
- NAMED EVIDENCE/CONCEPT: Taxila inscription and coins
- EXPLANATION: Anchors a Shaka line
- QUALIFICATION: Conquest sequence remains debated

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Early Shaka authority in the Taxila-Gandhara region
2. Taxila inscription and coins

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choosing by ruler-name familiarity.

CORRECT: Match group, source, region and chronology.

MAINS ANGLE

Anchors a Shaka line; limit the claim because conquest sequence remains debated.

STUDY LINK

Topic 16 hard practice.

HIGH**Hard MCQ 10**

Prelims Ancient
History

STATIC THEORY

- QUESTION: Rajuvula is best linked to:
- A. The Kshaharata line at Nashik
- B. The Mathura Shaka branch and the capture of Sagala
- C. The Yuezhi migration in Gansu
- D. The Besnagar embassy
- CORRECT ANSWER: B - The Mathura Shaka branch and the capture of Sagala
- NAMED EVIDENCE/CONCEPT: Shaka sequence
- EXPLANATION: Shows regional replacement of Indo-Greeks
- QUALIFICATION: Not all-India rule

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. The Mathura Shaka branch and the capture of Sagala
2. Shaka sequence

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Choosing by ruler-name familiarity.**CORRECT:** Match group, source, region and chronology.**MAINS ANGLE***Shows regional replacement of Indo-Greeks; limit the claim because not all-india rule.***STUDY LINK**

Topic 16 hard practice.

HIGH**Hard MCQ 11****Prelims** Ancient History**STATIC THEORY**

- QUESTION: The kshatrapa system should be understood as:
- A. A fixed Mauryan copied constitution
- B. A monastic hierarchy
- C. Delegated regional rule that could generate autonomy
- D. A Roman municipal office
- CORRECT ANSWER: C - Delegated regional rule that could generate autonomy
- NAMED EVIDENCE/CONCEPT: Titles and branch histories
- EXPLANATION: Explains expansion and fragmentation
- QUALIFICATION: Functions varied

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Delegated regional rule that could generate autonomy
2. Titles and branch histories

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Choosing by ruler-name familiarity.**CORRECT:** Match group, source, region and chronology.**MAINS ANGLE***Explains expansion and fragmentation; limit the claim because functions varied.***STUDY LINK**

Topic 16 hard practice.

HIGH**Hard MCQ 12****Prelims** Ancient History

STATIC THEORY

- QUESTION: Which distinction is correct?
- A. All three were Pahlavas
- B. Nahapana was Kushana
- C. Rudradaman was Indo-Greek
- D. Nahapana was Kshaharata; Chashtana and Rudradaman were Kardamaka
- CORRECT ANSWER: D - Nahapana was Kshaharata; Chashtana and Rudradaman were Kardamaka
- NAMED EVIDENCE/CONCEPT: Western Kshatrapa lines
- EXPLANATION: Prevents dynastic mixing
- QUALIFICATION: Dates still need inscription/coin checks

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Nahapana was Kshaharata; Chashtana and Rudradaman were Kardamaka
2. Western Kshatrapa lines

UPSC TRAPS

- WRONG:** Choosing by ruler-name familiarity.
- CORRECT:** Match group, source, region and chronology.

MAINS ANGLE

Prevents dynastic mixing; limit the claim because dates still need inscription/coin checks.

STUDY LINK

Topic 16 hard practice.

HIGH**Hard MCQ 13**Prelims Ancient
History**STATIC THEORY**

- QUESTION: Ushavadata's records are especially useful for:
- A. Donations, routes and Nahapana's southern political network
- B. Kanishka's Bactrian genealogy
- C. Menander's ashes
- D. Yuezhi migration
- CORRECT ANSWER: A - Donations, routes and Nahapana's southern political network
- NAMED EVIDENCE/CONCEPT: Nashik and Karle inscriptions
- EXPLANATION: Connects patronage and region
- QUALIFICATION: Not a fiscal census

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Donations, routes and Nahapana's southern political network
2. Nashik and Karle inscriptions

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Choosing by ruler-name familiarity.**CORRECT:** Match group, source, region and chronology.**MAINS ANGLE**

Connects patronage and region; limit the claim because not a fiscal census.

STUDY LINK

Topic 16 hard practice.

HIGH**Hard MCQ 14**

Prelims Ancient History

STATIC THEORY

- QUESTION: Nahapana's defeat is strongly supported by:
- A. Heliodorus' dedication
- B. Gautamiputra's restriking of Nahapana's coins
- C. Rabatak's genealogy
- D. Ai-Khanoum's theatre
- CORRECT ANSWER: B - Gautamiputra's restriking of Nahapana's coins
- NAMED EVIDENCE/CONCEPT: Overstruck silver coins
- EXPLANATION: Independent check on political displacement
- QUALIFICATION: Does not map every campaign

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Gautamiputra's restriking of Nahapana's coins
2. Overstruck silver coins

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Choosing by ruler-name familiarity.**CORRECT:** Match group, source, region and chronology.**MAINS ANGLE**

Independent check on political displacement; limit the claim because does not map every campaign.

STUDY LINK

Topic 16 hard practice.

HIGH**Hard MCQ 15**

Prelims Ancient History

STATIC THEORY

- QUESTION: Rudradaman's Junagadh inscription is dated to:
- A. Maurya year 72
- B. Gupta year 72
- C. Shaka year 72, about 150-151 CE
- D. Kanishka year 1 with certainty
- CORRECT ANSWER: C - Shaka year 72, about 150-151 CE
- NAMED EVIDENCE/CONCEPT: Dated Junagadh text
- EXPLANATION: Strong chronological anchor
- QUALIFICATION: Era founder remains separate debate

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Shaka year 72, about 150-151 CE
2. Dated Junagadh text

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choosing by ruler-name familiarity.

CORRECT: Match group, source, region and chronology.

MAINS ANGLE

Strong chronological anchor; limit the claim because era founder remains separate debate.

STUDY LINK

Topic 16 hard practice.

HIGH**Hard MCQ 16**Prelims Ancient
History**STATIC THEORY**

- QUESTION: Junagadh is analytically powerful because it combines:
- A. Only religious doctrine
- B. Only coin metrology
- C. Only a foreign travel report
- D. Public works, genealogy, conquest, Sanskrit and prashasti
- CORRECT ANSWER: D - Public works, genealogy, conquest, Sanskrit and prashasti
- NAMED EVIDENCE/CONCEPT: Rudradaman inscription
- EXPLANATION: Multi-dimensional evidence unit
- QUALIFICATION: Eulogy exaggerates

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Public works, genealogy, conquest, Sanskrit and prashasti
2. Rudradaman inscription

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Choosing by ruler-name familiarity.**CORRECT:** Match group, source, region and chronology.**MAINS ANGLE**

Multi-dimensional evidence unit; limit the claim because eulogy exaggerates.

STUDY LINK

Topic 16 hard practice.

HIGH**Hard MCQ 17**

Prelims Ancient History

STATIC THEORY

- QUESTION: Gondophares belongs to the:
- A. Indo-Parthian/Pahlava political layer
- B. Indo-Greek line
- C. Kardamaka line
- D. Kushana royal house
- CORRECT ANSWER: A - Indo-Parthian/Pahlava political layer
- NAMED EVIDENCE/CONCEPT: Coins and Takht-i-Bahi
- EXPLANATION: Preserves dynastic distinction
- QUALIFICATION: Territorial extent uncertain

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Indo-Parthian/Pahlava political layer
2. Coins and Takht-i-Bahi

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Choosing by ruler-name familiarity.**CORRECT:** Match group, source, region and chronology.**MAINS ANGLE**

Preserves dynastic distinction; limit the claim because territorial extent uncertain.

STUDY LINK

Topic 16 hard practice.

HIGH**Hard MCQ 18**

Prelims Ancient History

STATIC THEORY

- QUESTION: The most cautious use of the St Thomas-Gondophares tradition is:
- A. Contemporary court transcript
- B. Later tradition requiring independent corroboration
- C. Official Roman inscription
- D. Proof of empire-wide conversion
- CORRECT ANSWER: B - Later tradition requiring independent corroboration
- NAMED EVIDENCE/CONCEPT: Christian tradition
- EXPLANATION: May preserve memory
- QUALIFICATION: Not contemporary proof

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Later tradition requiring independent corroboration
2. Christian tradition

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choosing by ruler-name familiarity.

CORRECT: Match group, source, region and chronology.

MAINS ANGLE

May preserve memory; limit the claim because not contemporary proof.

STUDY LINK

Topic 16 hard practice.

HIGH**Hard MCQ 19**

Prelims Ancient
History

STATIC THEORY

- QUESTION: The Great Yuezhi movement is chiefly reconstructed through:
- A. Ashokan edicts alone
- B. Sangam anthologies
- C. Chinese texts combined with Central Asian archaeology
- D. Junagadh only
- CORRECT ANSWER: C - Chinese texts combined with Central Asian archaeology
- NAMED EVIDENCE/CONCEPT: Qian Hanshu/Hou Hanshu
- EXPLANATION: Explains migration framework
- QUALIFICATION: Ethnonyms are mediated

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Chinese texts combined with Central Asian archaeology
2. Qian Hanshu/Hou Hanshu

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Choosing by ruler-name familiarity.**CORRECT:** Match group, source, region and chronology.**MAINS ANGLE***Explains migration framework; limit the claim because ethnonyms are mediated.***STUDY LINK**

Topic 16 hard practice.

HIGH**Hard MCQ 20****Prelims** Ancient History**STATIC THEORY**

- QUESTION: Guishuang was:
- A. A Greek city
- B. A Shaka era
- C. A Satavahana district
- D. One of the Great Yuezhi principalities that became Kushana
- CORRECT ANSWER: D - One of the Great Yuezhi principalities that became Kushana
- NAMED EVIDENCE/CONCEPT: Chinese and numismatic reconstruction
- EXPLANATION: Explains Kushana formation
- QUALIFICATION: Do not project empire backward

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. One of the Great Yuezhi principalities that became Kushana
2. Chinese and numismatic reconstruction

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Choosing by ruler-name familiarity.**CORRECT:** Match group, source, region and chronology.**MAINS ANGLE***Explains Kushana formation; limit the claim because do not project empire backward.***STUDY LINK**

Topic 16 hard practice.

HIGH**Hard MCQ 21****Prelims** Ancient History

STATIC THEORY

- QUESTION: Kujula Kadphises is associated with:
- A. Unifying the Kushana branch and expanding south of Hindu Kush
- B. Composing Buddhacharita
- C. Repairing Sudarshana lake
- D. Defeating Strato III at Sagala
- CORRECT ANSWER: A - Unifying the Kushana branch and expanding south of Hindu Kush
- NAMED EVIDENCE/CONCEPT: Coins and Yuezhi sequence
- EXPLANATION: Foundational ruler
- QUALIFICATION: Date ranges vary

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Unifying the Kushana branch and expanding south of Hindu Kush
2. Coins and Yuezhi sequence

UPSC TRAPS

- WRONG:** Choosing by ruler-name familiarity.
- CORRECT:** Match group, source, region and chronology.

MAINS ANGLE

Foundational ruler; limit the claim because date ranges vary.

STUDY LINK

Topic 16 hard practice.

HIGH**Hard MCQ 22**Prelims Ancient
History**STATIC THEORY**

- QUESTION: The Vima Takto/Saddashkana problem demonstrates:
- A. A settled official genealogy
- B. Disputed inscriptional reading and dynastic reconstruction
- C. A Roman trade embargo
- D. A Buddhist council decree
- CORRECT ANSWER: B - Disputed inscriptional reading and dynastic reconstruction
- NAMED EVIDENCE/CONCEPT: Rabatak and coin debate
- EXPLANATION: Shows evidence revision
- QUALIFICATION: Name remains contested

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Disputed inscriptional reading and dynastic reconstruction
2. Rabatak and coin debate

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Choosing by ruler-name familiarity.**CORRECT:** Match group, source, region and chronology.**MAINS ANGLE***Shows evidence revision; limit the claim because name remains contested.***STUDY LINK**

Topic 16 hard practice.

HIGH**Hard MCQ 23****Prelims** Ancient History**STATIC THEORY**

- QUESTION: Vima Kadphises' coins are notable for:
- A. Only Buddhist symbols
- B. No royal portraits
- C. Gold/bronze issues and syncretic Shiva-linked imagery
- D. Purely Greek legends with no adaptation
- CORRECT ANSWER: C - Gold/bronze issues and syncretic Shiva-linked imagery
- NAMED EVIDENCE/CONCEPT: Vima coin types
- EXPLANATION: Monetary and religious policy
- QUALIFICATION: Image is not simple creed

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Gold/bronze issues and syncretic Shiva-linked imagery
2. Vima coin types

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Choosing by ruler-name familiarity.**CORRECT:** Match group, source, region and chronology.**MAINS ANGLE***Monetary and religious policy; limit the claim because image is not simple creed.***STUDY LINK**

Topic 16 hard practice.

HIGH**Hard MCQ 24****Prelims** Ancient History

STATIC THEORY

- QUESTION: Most scholars cited in the package date Kanishka's accession to:
- A. Exactly 78 BCE
- B. Exactly 320 CE
- C. About 185 BCE
- D. About 127 CE
- CORRECT ANSWER: D - About 127 CE
- NAMED EVIDENCE/CONCEPT: Yavanajataka-era reconstruction
- EXPLANATION: Current conventional anchor
- QUALIFICATION: Some scholars retain 78 CE

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. About 127 CE
2. Yavanajataka-era reconstruction

UPSC TRAPS

- WRONG:** Choosing by ruler-name familiarity.
- CORRECT:** Match group, source, region and chronology.

MAINS ANGLE

Current conventional anchor; limit the claim because some scholars retain 78 ce.

STUDY LINK

Topic 16 hard practice.

HIGH**Hard MCQ 25**Prelims Ancient
History**STATIC THEORY**

- QUESTION: The safest statement on the Shaka era is:
- A. It begins in 78 CE, but its founder and relation to Kanishka are debated
- B. Kanishka certainly founded it
- C. It began with Menander
- D. It is identical to Vikrama Samvat
- CORRECT ANSWER: A - It begins in 78 CE, but its founder and relation to Kanishka are debated
- NAMED EVIDENCE/CONCEPT: Era scholarship
- EXPLANATION: Prevents chronology error
- QUALIFICATION: Alternative proposals remain

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. It begins in 78 CE, but its founder and relation to Kanishka are debated
2. Era scholarship

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choosing by ruler-name familiarity.
CORRECT: Match group, source, region and chronology.

MAINS ANGLE

Prevents chronology error; limit the claim because alternative proposals remain.

STUDY LINK

Topic 16 hard practice.

HIGH**Hard MCQ 26**Prelims Ancient
History**STATIC THEORY**

- QUESTION: Rabatak is written in:
- A. Greek language in Brahmi
- B. Bactrian language using Greek script
- C. Sanskrit in Kharoshthi
- D. Prakrit in cuneiform
- CORRECT ANSWER: B - Bactrian language using Greek script
- NAMED EVIDENCE/CONCEPT: Rabatak inscription
- EXPLANATION: Separates language from script
- QUALIFICATION: Readings are specialist reconstructions

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Bactrian language using Greek script
2. Rabatak inscription

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choosing by ruler-name familiarity.
CORRECT: Match group, source, region and chronology.

MAINS ANGLE

Separates language from script; limit the claim because readings are specialist reconstructions.

STUDY LINK

Topic 16 hard practice.

HIGH**Hard MCQ 27**Prelims Ancient
History

STATIC THEORY

- QUESTION: Rabatak is crucial for:
- A. Satavahana matronymics
- B. Mauryan dhamma
- C. Kushana genealogy, royal ideology and an expansive city list
- D. Sangam port geography
- CORRECT ANSWER: C - Kushana genealogy, royal ideology and an expansive city list
- NAMED EVIDENCE/CONCEPT: Kanishka's inscription
- EXPLANATION: Links rulers and empire claims
- QUALIFICATION: Whole-India claim is rhetorical

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Kushana genealogy, royal ideology and an expansive city list
2. Kanishka's inscription

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choosing by ruler-name familiarity.

CORRECT: Match group, source, region and chronology.

MAINS ANGLE

Links rulers and empire claims; limit the claim because whole-india claim is rhetorical.

STUDY LINK

Topic 16 hard practice.

HIGH**Hard MCQ 28**

Prelims Ancient
History

STATIC THEORY

- QUESTION: Which statement about Kanishka's council is safest?
- A. A contemporary transcript fixes Kashmir beyond doubt
- B. It founded all Buddhism
- C. Coins describe the council
- D. Later traditions connect him with a conclave, but location and details are disputed
- CORRECT ANSWER: D - Later traditions connect him with a conclave, but location and details are disputed
- NAMED EVIDENCE/CONCEPT: Buddhist traditions
- EXPLANATION: Preserves patronage memory
- QUALIFICATION: Not secure contemporary documentation

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Later traditions connect him with a conclave, but location and details are disputed
2. Buddhist traditions

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Choosing by ruler-name familiarity.**CORRECT:** Match group, source, region and chronology.**MAINS ANGLE**

Preserves patronage memory; limit the claim because not secure contemporary documentation.

STUDY LINK

Topic 16 hard practice.

HIGH**Hard MCQ 29**Prelims Ancient
History**STATIC THEORY**

- QUESTION: Kushana political geography is best modelled as:
- A. A multi-centred network with direct and subordinate tiers
- B. One capital and uniform districts everywhere
- C. Only a Punjab kingdom
- D. A purely maritime empire
- CORRECT ANSWER: A - A multi-centred network with direct and subordinate tiers
- NAMED EVIDENCE/CONCEPT: Bactria-Purushapura-Mathura evidence
- EXPLANATION: Fits varied control
- QUALIFICATION: Boundaries remain approximate

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. A multi-centred network with direct and subordinate tiers
2. Bactria-Purushapura-Mathura evidence

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Choosing by ruler-name familiarity.**CORRECT:** Match group, source, region and chronology.**MAINS ANGLE**

Fits varied control; limit the claim because boundaries remain approximate.

STUDY LINK

Topic 16 hard practice.

HIGH**Hard MCQ 30**Prelims Ancient
History

STATIC THEORY

- QUESTION: A Kushana coin found in Bengal proves:
- A. Direct taxation beyond doubt
- B. Contact or circulation, not automatically annexation
- C. A Kushana capital there
- D. The coin was minted there
- CORRECT ANSWER: B - Contact or circulation, not automatically annexation
- NAMED EVIDENCE/CONCEPT: Distribution method
- EXPLANATION: Protects against map inflation
- QUALIFICATION: Context may refine inference

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Contact or circulation, not automatically annexation
2. Distribution method

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choosing by ruler-name familiarity.
CORRECT: Match group, source, region and chronology.

MAINS ANGLE

Protects against map inflation; limit the claim because context may refine inference.

STUDY LINK

Topic 16 hard practice.

HIGH**Hard MCQ 31**Prelims Ancient
History**STATIC THEORY**

- QUESTION: Devaputra and related Kushana titles express:
- A. Republican equality
- B. Monastic ordination
- C. A close royal-divine relationship and exalted sovereignty
- D. Guild autonomy
- CORRECT ANSWER: C - A close royal-divine relationship and exalted sovereignty
- NAMED EVIDENCE/CONCEPT: Titles and iconography
- EXPLANATION: Royal ideology
- QUALIFICATION: Literal worship remains debated

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. A close royal-divine relationship and exalted sovereignty
2. Titles and iconography

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Choosing by ruler-name familiarity.**CORRECT:** Match group, source, region and chronology.**MAINS ANGLE***Royal ideology; limit the claim because literal worship remains debated.***STUDY LINK**

Topic 16 hard practice.

HIGH**Hard MCQ 32****Prelims** Ancient
History**STATIC THEORY**

- QUESTION: The Mat devakula evidence proves most securely:
- A. Universal worship of kings
- B. A Buddhist-only temple
- C. The first stone temple in India
- D. Royal portraiture and a monumental shrine complex
- CORRECT ANSWER: D - Royal portraiture and a monumental shrine complex
- NAMED EVIDENCE/CONCEPT: Mat inscriptions/statues
- EXPLANATION: Shows royal image politics
- QUALIFICATION: Cult function unresolved

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Royal portraiture and a monumental shrine complex
2. Mat inscriptions/statues

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Choosing by ruler-name familiarity.**CORRECT:** Match group, source, region and chronology.**MAINS ANGLE***Shows royal image politics; limit the claim because cult function unresolved.***STUDY LINK**

Topic 16 hard practice.

HIGH**Hard MCQ 33****Prelims** Ancient
History

STATIC THEORY

- QUESTION: Kushana coin pantheons are best read as:
- A. Imperial engagement with diverse religious constituencies
- B. Exclusive personal Buddhism
- C. Random decoration without political meaning
- D. Proof of one syncretic popular religion
- CORRECT ANSWER: A - Imperial engagement with diverse religious constituencies
- NAMED EVIDENCE/CONCEPT: Named deities on coins
- EXPLANATION: Explains plural policy
- QUALIFICATION: Popular reception is unknown

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Imperial engagement with diverse religious constituencies
2. Named deities on coins

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choosing by ruler-name familiarity.
CORRECT: Match group, source, region and chronology.

MAINS ANGLE

Explains plural policy; limit the claim because popular reception is unknown.

STUDY LINK

Topic 16 hard practice.

HIGH**Hard MCQ 34**Prelims Ancient
History**STATIC THEORY**

- QUESTION: The phrase 'Silk Road control' should mean:
- A. Exclusive ownership of one road
- B. Strategic participation in and revenue from route networks
- C. No maritime trade
- D. Chinese political rule over India
- CORRECT ANSWER: B - Strategic participation in and revenue from route networks
- NAMED EVIDENCE/CONCEPT: Route positioning
- EXPLANATION: Links empire and exchange
- QUALIFICATION: Traffic volume varied

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Strategic participation in and revenue from route networks
2. Route positioning

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Choosing by ruler-name familiarity.**CORRECT:** Match group, source, region and chronology.**MAINS ANGLE***Links empire and exchange; limit the claim because traffic volume varied.***STUDY LINK**

Topic 16 hard practice.

HIGH**Hard MCQ 35****Prelims** Ancient History**STATIC THEORY**

- QUESTION: Kushana gold coinage proves:
- A. Universal peasant prosperity
- B. End of barter
- C. High-value monetary capacity in selected circuits
- D. Roman political control
- CORRECT ANSWER: C - High-value monetary capacity in selected circuits
- NAMED EVIDENCE/CONCEPT: Gold issues
- EXPLANATION: Economic and royal scale
- QUALIFICATION: Distribution was unequal

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. High-value monetary capacity in selected circuits
2. Gold issues

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Choosing by ruler-name familiarity.**CORRECT:** Match group, source, region and chronology.**MAINS ANGLE***Economic and royal scale; limit the claim because distribution was unequal.***STUDY LINK**

Topic 16 hard practice.

HIGH**Hard MCQ 36****Prelims** Ancient History

STATIC THEORY

- QUESTION: The Huvishka-era Mathura guild inscription shows:
- A. A royal land census
- B. A Greek theatre company
- C. A Sasanian tax reform
- D. Permanent investment with guilds for religious-charitable purposes
- CORRECT ANSWER: D - Permanent investment with guilds for religious-charitable purposes
- NAMED EVIDENCE/CONCEPT: Akshaya-nivi endowment
- EXPLANATION: Guild finance and welfare
- QUALIFICATION: One record is not universal

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Permanent investment with guilds for religious-charitable purposes
2. Akshaya-nivi endowment

UPSC TRAPS

- WRONG:** Choosing by ruler-name familiarity.
- CORRECT:** Match group, source, region and chronology.

MAINS ANGLE

Guild finance and welfare; limit the claim because one record is not universal.

STUDY LINK

Topic 16 hard practice.

HIGH**Hard MCQ 37**Prelims Ancient
History**STATIC THEORY**

- QUESTION: Kanishka's religious policy is best summarised as:
- A. Major Buddhist patronage within a wider plural royal pantheon
- B. Exclusive Buddhist iconography
- C. Hostility to Shiva
- D. Abolition of Iranian cults
- CORRECT ANSWER: A - Major Buddhist patronage within a wider plural royal pantheon
- NAMED EVIDENCE/CONCEPT: Coins plus Buddhist monuments
- EXPLANATION: Balanced evidence
- QUALIFICATION: Personal belief cannot be fully recovered

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Major Buddhist patronage within a wider plural royal pantheon
2. Coins plus Buddhist monuments

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Choosing by ruler-name familiarity.**CORRECT:** Match group, source, region and chronology.**MAINS ANGLE**

Balanced evidence; limit the claim because personal belief cannot be fully recovered.

STUDY LINK

Topic 16 hard practice.

HIGH**Hard MCQ 38**

Prelims Ancient History

STATIC THEORY

- QUESTION: Which Mahayana claim is unsafe?
- A. Mahayana grew through longer doctrinal and social processes
- B. Kanishka single-handedly founded Mahayana
- C. Kanishka is remembered as a patron
- D. Merchant-monastic networks mattered
- CORRECT ANSWER: B - Kanishka single-handedly founded Mahayana
- NAMED EVIDENCE/CONCEPT: Buddhist history
- EXPLANATION: Avoids ruler-centred origin myth
- QUALIFICATION: Traditions still value his patronage

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Kanishka single-handedly founded Mahayana
2. Buddhist history

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Choosing by ruler-name familiarity.**CORRECT:** Match group, source, region and chronology.**MAINS ANGLE**

Avoids ruler-centred origin myth; limit the claim because traditions still value his patronage.

STUDY LINK

Topic 16 hard practice.

HIGH**Hard MCQ 39**

Prelims Ancient History

STATIC THEORY

- QUESTION: Gandhara art is best defined as:
- A. Pure Greek art
- B. A Mathura copy
- C. A Buddhist programme in a layered Hellenised north-western idiom
- D. A Gupta-only school
- CORRECT ANSWER: C - A Buddhist programme in a layered Hellenised north-western idiom
- NAMED EVIDENCE/CONCEPT: Regional sculpture
- EXPLANATION: Balances subject and form
- QUALIFICATION: Phases and workshops vary

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. A Buddhist programme in a layered Hellenised north-western idiom
2. Regional sculpture

UPSC TRAPS

- WRONG:** Choosing by ruler-name familiarity.
- CORRECT:** Match group, source, region and chronology.

MAINS ANGLE

Balances subject and form; limit the claim because phases and workshops vary.

STUDY LINK

Topic 16 hard practice.

HIGH**Hard MCQ 40**Prelims Ancient
History**STATIC THEORY**

- QUESTION: Greco-Bactrian elements in Gandhara are most visible in:
- A. Kshatrappa tax titles
- B. Tamil-Brahmi graffiti
- C. Mauryan dhamma formulas
- D. Body modelling, wavy hair and folded drapery
- CORRECT ANSWER: D - Body modelling, wavy hair and folded drapery
- NAMED EVIDENCE/CONCEPT: Formal art analysis
- EXPLANATION: Answers 2019 demand
- QUALIFICATION: Not proof of Greek artist ethnicity

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Body modelling, wavy hair and folded drapery
2. Formal art analysis

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Choosing by ruler-name familiarity.**CORRECT:** Match group, source, region and chronology.**MAINS ANGLE**

Answers 2019 demand; limit the claim because not proof of greek artist ethnicity.

STUDY LINK

Topic 16 hard practice.

HIGH**Hard MCQ 41**
Prelims Ancient
History
STATIC THEORY

- QUESTION: Central Asian elements in Gandhara include especially:
- A. Kushana patronage, frontier costume and transregional workshop context
- B. Only Corinthian pillars
- C. Only Pali canon texts
- D. Only Gupta land grants
- CORRECT ANSWER: A - Kushana patronage, frontier costume and transregional workshop context
- NAMED EVIDENCE/CONCEPT: Patronage/context
- EXPLANATION: Separates strand from Hellenism
- QUALIFICATION: Central Asia was internally diverse

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Kushana patronage, frontier costume and transregional workshop context
2. Patronage/context

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Choosing by ruler-name familiarity.**CORRECT:** Match group, source, region and chronology.**MAINS ANGLE**

Separates strand from Hellenism; limit the claim because central asia was internally diverse.

STUDY LINK

Topic 16 hard practice.

HIGH**Hard MCQ 42**
Prelims Ancient
History

STATIC THEORY

- QUESTION: Mathura differs from Gandhara through:
- A. No Buddha images
- B. Red sandstone, older local idioms and broader surviving religious range
- C. Pure Roman marble
- D. Absence of royal portraiture
- CORRECT ANSWER: B - Red sandstone, older local idioms and broader surviving religious range
- NAMED EVIDENCE/CONCEPT: Mathura corpus
- EXPLANATION: Strong comparison axis
- QUALIFICATION: Interaction still occurred

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Red sandstone, older local idioms and broader surviving religious range
2. Mathura corpus

UPSC TRAPS

- WRONG:** Choosing by ruler-name familiarity.
- CORRECT:** Match group, source, region and chronology.

MAINS ANGLE

Strong comparison axis; limit the claim because interaction still occurred.

STUDY LINK

Topic 16 hard practice.

HIGH**Hard MCQ 43**Prelims Ancient
History**STATIC THEORY**

- QUESTION: The Buddha-image emergence debate supports:
- A. A settled Gandhara priority
- B. Mahayana alone as sole cause
- C. Multiple centres and causes rather than a single Greek invention
- D. Total disappearance of symbols
- CORRECT ANSWER: C - Multiple centres and causes rather than a single Greek invention
- NAMED EVIDENCE/CONCEPT: Gandhara-Mathura evidence
- EXPLANATION: Rejects monocausality
- QUALIFICATION: Precise priority remains debated

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Multiple centres and causes rather than a single Greek invention
2. Gandhara-Mathura evidence

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choosing by ruler-name familiarity.

CORRECT: Match group, source, region and chronology.

MAINS ANGLE

Rejects monocausality; limit the claim because precise priority remains debated.

STUDY LINK

Topic 16 hard practice.

HIGH**Hard MCQ 44**Prelims Ancient
History**STATIC THEORY**

- QUESTION: Which pairing is correct?
- A. Heliodorus-Sanskrit in Kharoshthi
- B. Junagadh-Greek in Brahmi
- C. Milindapanho-official Prakrit edict
- D. Rabatak-Bactrian in Greek script
- CORRECT ANSWER: D - Rabatak-Bactrian in Greek script
- NAMED EVIDENCE/CONCEPT: Script-language method
- EXPLANATION: Tests precise source reading
- QUALIFICATION: Translations remain scholarly

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Rabatak-Bactrian in Greek script
2. Script-language method

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choosing by ruler-name familiarity.

CORRECT: Match group, source, region and chronology.

MAINS ANGLE

Tests precise source reading; limit the claim because translations remain scholarly.

STUDY LINK

Topic 16 hard practice.

HIGH**Hard MCQ 45**Prelims Ancient
History

STATIC THEORY

- QUESTION: Rudradaman's Sanskrit inscription demonstrates:
- A. Expansion of courtly Sanskrit while Prakrit continued
- B. Immediate end of Prakrit
- C. Kushana Bactrian policy
- D. A Greek royal conversion
- CORRECT ANSWER: A - Expansion of courtly Sanskrit while Prakrit continued
- NAMED EVIDENCE/CONCEPT: Junagadh language
- EXPLANATION: Language-order change
- QUALIFICATION: Not instant replacement

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Expansion of courtly Sanskrit while Prakrit continued
2. Junagadh language

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choosing by ruler-name familiarity.

CORRECT: Match group, source, region and chronology.

MAINS ANGLE

Language-order change; limit the claim because not instant replacement.

STUDY LINK

Topic 16 hard practice.

HIGH**Hard MCQ 46**Prelims Ancient
History**STATIC THEORY**

- QUESTION: The best evidence-supported knowledge-exchange claim is:
- A. Greeks created all Indian science
- B. Greek astral vocabulary and texts influenced Indian astronomy/astrology selectively
- C. India received no external ideas
- D. Kushanas invented Sanskrit
- CORRECT ANSWER: B - Greek astral vocabulary and texts influenced Indian astronomy/astrology selectively
- NAMED EVIDENCE/CONCEPT: Yavanajataka/technical terms
- EXPLANATION: Specific transfer
- QUALIFICATION: Direction and dating need precision

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Greek astral vocabulary and texts influenced Indian astronomy/astrology selectively
2. Yavanajataka/technical terms

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choosing by ruler-name familiarity.
CORRECT: Match group, source, region and chronology.

MAINS ANGLE

Specific transfer; limit the claim because direction and dating need precision.

STUDY LINK

Topic 16 hard practice.

HIGH**Hard MCQ 47**Prelims Ancient
History**STATIC THEORY**

- QUESTION: 'Indianisation' should be reframed as:
- A. One-way cultural surrender
- B. Complete disappearance of difference
- C. Reciprocal adaptation, legitimisation and synthesis
- D. A purely biological process
- CORRECT ANSWER: C - Reciprocal adaptation, legitimisation and synthesis
- NAMED EVIDENCE/CONCEPT: Cross-source synthesis
- EXPLANATION: Captures agency on several sides
- QUALIFICATION: Power remained unequal

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Reciprocal adaptation, legitimisation and synthesis
2. Cross-source synthesis

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choosing by ruler-name familiarity.
CORRECT: Match group, source, region and chronology.

MAINS ANGLE

Captures agency on several sides; limit the claim because power remained unequal.

STUDY LINK

Topic 16 hard practice.

HIGH**Hard MCQ 48**Prelims Ancient
History

STATIC THEORY

- QUESTION: The decline of Kushana power is linked most securely in the west to:
- A. Alexander's invasion
- B. Ashoka's dhamma
- C. Chola naval conquest
- D. Sasanian expansion and loss of western territories
- CORRECT ANSWER: D - Sasanian expansion and loss of western territories
- NAMED EVIDENCE/CONCEPT: Later Kushana context
- EXPLANATION: External pressure with regional effect
- QUALIFICATION: Not sole all-region cause

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Sasanian expansion and loss of western territories
2. Later Kushana context

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choosing by ruler-name familiarity.
CORRECT: Match group, source, region and chronology.

MAINS ANGLE

External pressure with regional effect; limit the claim because not sole all-region cause.

STUDY LINK

Topic 16 hard practice.

HIGH**Remedial MCQ 49**Prelims Ancient
History**STATIC THEORY**

- QUESTION: Correct the chronology trap:
- A. Shaka era 78 CE; Kanishka commonly c. 127 CE
- B. Kanishka 78 BCE
- C. Menander founded 78 CE
- D. Vikrama and Shaka eras are identical
- CORRECT ANSWER: A - Shaka era 78 CE; Kanishka commonly c. 127 CE
- NAMED EVIDENCE/CONCEPT: Era separation
- EXPLANATION: Repairs the most frequent error
- QUALIFICATION: Older scholarship differs

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Shaka era 78 CE; Kanishka commonly c. 127 CE
2. Era separation

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choosing by ruler-name familiarity.
CORRECT: Match group, source, region and chronology.

MAINS ANGLE

Repairs the most frequent error; limit the claim because older scholarship differs.

STUDY LINK

Topic 16 remedial practice.

HIGH**Remedial MCQ 50**

Prelims Ancient History

STATIC THEORY

- QUESTION: Correct the identity trap:
- A. Nagarjuna authored the transcript
- B. Nagasena is Milinda's interlocutor; Nagarjuna is different
- C. Nagasena was Antialcidas
- D. Milinda was Rudradaman
- CORRECT ANSWER: B - Nagasena is Milinda's interlocutor; Nagarjuna is different
- NAMED EVIDENCE/CONCEPT: Milindapanho
- EXPLANATION: Direct PYQ repair
- QUALIFICATION: Authorship remains literary history

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Nagasena is Milinda's interlocutor; Nagarjuna is different
2. Milindapanho

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choosing by ruler-name familiarity.
CORRECT: Match group, source, region and chronology.

MAINS ANGLE

Direct PYQ repair; limit the claim because authorship remains literary history.

STUDY LINK

Topic 16 remedial practice.

HIGH**Remedial MCQ 51**

Prelims Ancient History

STATIC THEORY

- QUESTION: Correct the dynasty trap:
- A. Both Kushana
- B. Both Pahlava
- C. Nahapana-Kshaharata; Rudradaman-Kardamaka
- D. Nahapana-Kardamaka; Rudradaman-Kshaharata
- CORRECT ANSWER: C - Nahapana-Kshaharata; Rudradaman-Kardamaka
- NAMED EVIDENCE/CONCEPT: Western Kshatrapas
- EXPLANATION: Separates branches
- QUALIFICATION: Regional sequence remains bounded

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Nahapana-Kshaharata; Rudradaman-Kardamaka
2. Western Kshatrapas

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choosing by ruler-name familiarity.
CORRECT: Match group, source, region and chronology.

MAINS ANGLE

Separates branches; limit the claim because regional sequence remains bounded.

STUDY LINK

Topic 16 remedial practice.

HIGH**Remedial MCQ 52**Prelims Ancient
History**STATIC THEORY**

- QUESTION: Correct the source trap:
- A. Every coin marks annexation
- B. Coins cannot identify rulers
- C. Only texts matter
- D. Coin distribution may show circulation without direct rule
- CORRECT ANSWER: D - Coin distribution may show circulation without direct rule
- NAMED EVIDENCE/CONCEPT: Numismatic method
- EXPLANATION: Prevents inflated maps
- QUALIFICATION: Context can strengthen political inference

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Coin distribution may show circulation without direct rule
2. Numismatic method

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Choosing by ruler-name familiarity.**CORRECT:** Match group, source, region and chronology.**MAINS ANGLE***Prevents inflated maps; limit the claim because context can strengthen political inference.***STUDY LINK**

Topic 16 remedial practice.

HIGH**Remedial MCQ 53****Prelims** Ancient History**STATIC THEORY**

- QUESTION: Correct the art trap:
- A. Gandhara's Buddhist subjects used layered Hellenised forms
- B. Gandhara was imported Greek pagan art
- C. Mathura copied every Gandhara form
- D. Greek art alone caused image worship
- CORRECT ANSWER: A - Gandhara's Buddhist subjects used layered Hellenised forms
- NAMED EVIDENCE/CONCEPT: Gandhara analysis
- EXPLANATION: Restores local agency
- QUALIFICATION: Workshops remain diverse

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Gandhara's Buddhist subjects used layered Hellenised forms
2. Gandhara analysis

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Choosing by ruler-name familiarity.**CORRECT:** Match group, source, region and chronology.**MAINS ANGLE***Restores local agency; limit the claim because workshops remain diverse.***STUDY LINK**

Topic 16 remedial practice.

HIGH**Remedial MCQ 54****Prelims** Ancient History

STATIC THEORY

- QUESTION: Correct the Mathura trap:
- A. Mathura used only grey schist
- B. Mathura had indigenous red-sandstone workshops and plural patronage
- C. Mathura had no Jain art
- D. Mathura was outside Kushana power
- CORRECT ANSWER: B - Mathura had indigenous red-sandstone workshops and plural patronage
- NAMED EVIDENCE/CONCEPT: Mathura corpus
- EXPLANATION: Restores regional distinction
- QUALIFICATION: Interaction with Gandhara continued

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Mathura had indigenous red-sandstone workshops and plural patronage
2. Mathura corpus

UPSC TRAPS

- WRONG:** Choosing by ruler-name familiarity.
- CORRECT:** Match group, source, region and chronology.

MAINS ANGLE

Restores regional distinction; limit the claim because interaction with gandhara continued.

STUDY LINK

Topic 16 remedial practice.

HIGH**Remedial MCQ 55**Prelims Ancient
History**STATIC THEORY**

- QUESTION: Correct the religion trap:
- A. His coins were only Buddhist
- B. He founded Buddhism
- C. Kanishka was a major Buddhist patron with plural coin imagery
- D. He banned Iranian gods
- CORRECT ANSWER: C - Kanishka was a major Buddhist patron with plural coin imagery
- NAMED EVIDENCE/CONCEPT: Coins and monuments
- EXPLANATION: Balances patronage and policy
- QUALIFICATION: Personal belief remains incomplete

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Kanishka was a major Buddhist patron with plural coin imagery
2. Coins and monuments

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Choosing by ruler-name familiarity.**CORRECT:** Match group, source, region and chronology.**MAINS ANGLE**

Balances patronage and policy; limit the claim because personal belief remains incomplete.

STUDY LINK

Topic 16 remedial practice.

HIGH**Remedial MCQ 56**

Prelims Ancient History

STATIC THEORY

- QUESTION: Correct the council trap:
- A. A contemporary transcript fixes Kashmir
- B. No tradition exists
- C. Rabatak records the council
- D. A Kanishka-linked conclave is traditional; location/details are disputed
- CORRECT ANSWER: D - A Kanishka-linked conclave is traditional; location/details are disputed
- NAMED EVIDENCE/CONCEPT: Source criticism
- EXPLANATION: Separates tradition from inscription
- QUALIFICATION: Patronage remains significant

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. A Kanishka-linked conclave is traditional; location/details are disputed
2. Source criticism

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Choosing by ruler-name familiarity.**CORRECT:** Match group, source, region and chronology.**MAINS ANGLE**

Separates tradition from inscription; limit the claim because patronage remains significant.

STUDY LINK

Topic 16 remedial practice.

HIGH**Remedial MCQ 57**

Prelims Ancient History

STATIC THEORY

- QUESTION: Correct the Pahlava trap:
- A. Gondophares was Indo-Parthian, distinct from Shaka rulers
- B. Gondophares was Kardamaka
- C. Pahlava means Kushana
- D. All were Indo-Greeks
- CORRECT ANSWER: A - Gondophares was Indo-Parthian, distinct from Shaka rulers
- NAMED EVIDENCE/CONCEPT: Dynastic terminology
- EXPLANATION: Preserves sequence
- QUALIFICATION: Texts sometimes pair Shaka-Pahlava

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Gondophares was Indo-Parthian, distinct from Shaka rulers
2. Dynastic terminology

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choosing by ruler-name familiarity.

CORRECT: Match group, source, region and chronology.

MAINS ANGLE

Preserves sequence; limit the claim because texts sometimes pair shaka-pahlava.

STUDY LINK

Topic 16 remedial practice.

HIGH**Remedial MCQ 58**Prelims Ancient
History**STATIC THEORY**

- QUESTION: Correct the trade trap:
- A. One road was owned completely by Kanishka
- B. Silk Roads were changing networks; Kushanas occupied strategic nodes
- C. Only sea trade mattered
- D. Roman coins prove colonies
- CORRECT ANSWER: B - Silk Roads were changing networks; Kushanas occupied strategic nodes
- NAMED EVIDENCE/CONCEPT: Trade method
- EXPLANATION: Adds network and scale caution
- QUALIFICATION: Volumes vary

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Silk Roads were changing networks; Kushanas occupied strategic nodes
2. Trade method

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Choosing by ruler-name familiarity.**CORRECT:** Match group, source, region and chronology.**MAINS ANGLE***Adds network and scale caution; limit the claim because volumes vary.***STUDY LINK**

Topic 16 remedial practice.

HIGH**Remedial MCQ 59****Prelims** Ancient History**STATIC THEORY**

- QUESTION: Correct the social trap:
- A. Foreigners lost all prior forms instantly
- B. Manu's label is a census
- C. Integration was reciprocal and regionally varied
- D. Only kings participated
- CORRECT ANSWER: C - Integration was reciprocal and regionally varied
- NAMED EVIDENCE/CONCEPT: Cultural synthesis
- EXPLANATION: Adds actors and power
- QUALIFICATION: Archive is elite-heavy

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Integration was reciprocal and regionally varied
2. Cultural synthesis

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Choosing by ruler-name familiarity.**CORRECT:** Match group, source, region and chronology.**MAINS ANGLE***Adds actors and power; limit the claim because archive is elite-heavy.***STUDY LINK**

Topic 16 remedial practice.

HIGH**Remedial MCQ 60****Prelims** Ancient History

STATIC THEORY

- QUESTION: Correct the decline trap:
- A. Kushana fall ended Buddhism
- B. One invasion ended all regions
- C. Coins and art vanished immediately
- D. Political fragmentation coexisted with cultural and commercial continuity
- CORRECT ANSWER: D - Political fragmentation coexisted with cultural and commercial continuity
- NAMED EVIDENCE/CONCEPT: Ended-persisted-transformed
- EXPLANATION: Prevents dark-age narrative
- QUALIFICATION: Regional timings differ

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Political fragmentation coexisted with cultural and commercial continuity
2. Ended-persisted-transformed

UPSC TRAPS

- WRONG:** Choosing by ruler-name familiarity.
- CORRECT:** Match group, source, region and chronology.

MAINS ANGLE

Prevents dark-age narrative; limit the claim because regional timings differ.

STUDY LINK

Topic 16 remedial practice.

HIGH**Mains 10M-1 - Distinguish the Central Asian polities**

10 marks GS-I
Ancient History

NEWS TRIGGER

Distinguish the Indo-Greeks, Shakas, Pahlavas and Kushanas in terms of origin, political form and evidence. (10 marks, 150 words)

STATIC THEORY

- QUESTION: Distinguish the Indo-Greeks, Shakas, Pahlavas and Kushanas in terms of origin, political form and evidence. (10 marks, 150 words)
- DIRECT THESIS: These were distinct but overlapping frontier polities, not one undifferentiated succession of foreigners.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 1 - CLAIM/NAMED EVIDENCE: Indo-Greeks: Bactrian Greek lines south of Hindu Kush; portrait and bilingual coins identify rulers such as Menander.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 1 - SIGNIFICANCE: Numismatic form, legend and metal make authority or exchange materially testable.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 1 - LIMIT: Coin imagery does not automatically reveal personal belief, and circulation does not equal a political frontier.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 2 - CLAIM/NAMED EVIDENCE: Shakas: Scythian-origin branches at Taxila, Mathura and western India; kshatrpa titles and the Nahapana/Rudradaman record.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 2 - SIGNIFICANCE: Material, workshop and iconographic evidence identifies a regional practice and its patronage context.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 2 - LIMIT: Style cannot identify an artist's ethnicity or settle priority, belief and political control by itself.

- EVIDENCE UNIT 3 - CLAIM/NAMED EVIDENCE: Pahlavas: Indo-Parthian layer centred on Gondophares, anchored by coins and Takht-i-Bahi.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 3 - SIGNIFICANCE: Numismatic form, legend and metal make authority or exchange materially testable.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 3 - LIMIT: Coin imagery does not automatically reveal personal belief, and circulation does not equal a political frontier.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 4 - CLAIM/NAMED EVIDENCE: Kushanas: Guishuang branch of Great Yuezhi, consolidated by Kujula and clarified by Rabatak.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 4 - SIGNIFICANCE: A named and locatable inscription gives a stronger chronological or ideological anchor than a free-floating tradition.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 4 - LIMIT: Epigraphs remain selective; prashasti, damaged readings and universalising claims require corroboration.
- BALANCE/SOURCE CRITICISM: Regional overlap and shared titles/coin conventions do not erase differences in origin or dynasty.
- REASONED CONCLUSION: The correct historical unit is a connected frontier world with multiple political experiments.
- WHY THIS EARNS MARKS: Directive fidelity; claim -> named evidence -> significance -> qualification; marks-proportionate density; reasoned verdict.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. These were distinct but overlapping frontier polities, not one undifferentiated succession of foreigners.
2. Evidence target: 4 named units.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Listing evidence without stating what it proves.

CORRECT: Interpret and qualify every named unit.

MAINS ANGLE

The correct historical unit is a connected frontier world with multiple political experiments.

STUDY LINK

Topic 16 original solved Mains bank.

HIGH**Mains 10M-2 - Menander and the Milindapanho**

10 marks GS-I
Ancient History

NEWS TRIGGER

Assess the historical value and limitations of the Milindapanho for understanding Menander and Indo-Greek interaction. (10 marks, 150 words)

STATIC THEORY

- QUESTION: Assess the historical value and limitations of the Milindapanho for understanding Menander and Indo-Greek interaction. (10 marks, 150 words)
- DIRECT THESIS: The Milindapanho is indispensable for Buddhist intellectual memory but must be correlated with Menander's coins.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 1 - CLAIM/NAMED EVIDENCE: The text identifies Milinda with a questioning king and structures Buddhist teaching through dialogue with Nagasena.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 1 - SIGNIFICANCE: The textual witness preserves intellectual memory, external chronology or a perspective missing from material evidence.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 1 - LIMIT: Genre, redaction, translation, distance and authorial purpose limit literal event reconstruction.

- EVIDENCE UNIT 2 - CLAIM/NAMED EVIDENCE: Menander's extensive portrait/bilingual coin corpus independently anchors political authority and circulation.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 2 - SIGNIFICANCE: Numismatic form, legend and metal make authority or exchange materially testable.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 2 - LIMIT: Coin imagery does not automatically reveal personal belief, and circulation does not equal a political frontier.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 3 - CLAIM/NAMED EVIDENCE: Sagala provides a plausible political-urban setting, while Plutarch preserves a separate posthumous memory.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 3 - SIGNIFICANCE: The textual witness preserves intellectual memory, external chronology or a perspective missing from material evidence.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 3 - LIMIT: Genre, redaction, translation, distance and authorial purpose limit literal event reconstruction.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 4 - CLAIM/NAMED EVIDENCE: Genre and redaction mean the conversation cannot be read as a verbatim court transcript or full biography.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 4 - SIGNIFICANCE: The named unit anchors one required dimension of the answer in precise historical evidence.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 4 - LIMIT: Its reach must remain bounded by date, region, source class and the uncertainty of reconstruction.
- BALANCE/SOURCE CRITICISM: Literary construction does not make the text useless; it changes the historical questions it can answer.
- REASONED CONCLUSION: Used with numismatics, it reveals the cultural afterlife of Indo-Greek kingship more securely than event detail.
- WHY THIS EARNS MARKS: Directive fidelity; claim -> named evidence -> significance -> qualification; marks-proportionate density; reasoned verdict.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. The Milindapanho is indispensable for Buddhist intellectual memory but must be correlated with Menander's coins.
2. Evidence target: 4 named units.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Listing evidence without stating what it proves.

CORRECT: Interpret and qualify every named unit.

MAINS ANGLE

Used with numismatics, it reveals the cultural afterlife of Indo-Greek kingship more securely than event detail.

STUDY LINK

Topic 16 original solved Mains bank.

HIGH**Mains 10M-3 - Satrap system**

10 marks GS-I
Ancient History

NEWS TRIGGER

Explain the kshatrapa system and its political significance in post-Mauryan India. (10 marks, 150 words)

STATIC THEORY

- QUESTION: Explain the kshatrapa system and its political significance in post-Mauryan India. (10 marks, 150 words)
- DIRECT THESIS: The kshatrapa system was a flexible form of delegated regional rule that enabled expansion but encouraged autonomy.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 1 - CLAIM/NAMED EVIDENCE: The Iranian-derived title was adapted by Shaka rulers rather than copied as an unchanged institution.

- EVIDENCE UNIT 1 - SIGNIFICANCE: Titulature and hierarchy expose how sovereignty, delegation and royal ideology were organised.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 1 - LIMIT: A shared title is not a complete constitution, and actual powers varied by ruler, place and time.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 2 - CLAIM/NAMED EVIDENCE: Rajuvula's progression from kshatrapa to mahakshatrapa shows office becoming sovereign status.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 2 - SIGNIFICANCE: Titulature and hierarchy expose how sovereignty, delegation and royal ideology were organised.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 2 - LIMIT: A shared title is not a complete constitution, and actual powers varied by ruler, place and time.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 3 - CLAIM/NAMED EVIDENCE: Nahapana's varied titles and regional coin-inscription network reveal practical autonomy.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 3 - SIGNIFICANCE: Numismatic form, legend and metal make authority or exchange materially testable.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 3 - LIMIT: Coin imagery does not automatically reveal personal belief, and circulation does not equal a political frontier.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 4 - CLAIM/NAMED EVIDENCE: Kardamaka senior-junior rule under Chashtana, Jayadaman and Rudradaman displays dynastic co-rule.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 4 - SIGNIFICANCE: The named unit anchors one required dimension of the answer in precise historical evidence.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 4 - LIMIT: Its reach must remain bounded by date, region, source class and the uncertainty of reconstruction.
- BALANCE/SOURCE CRITICISM: Titles do not provide a complete administrative constitution, and practice varied by region.
- REASONED CONCLUSION: Its significance lies in the trade-off between low-cost imperial reach and centrifugal regional power.
- WHY THIS EARNS MARKS: Directive fidelity; claim -> named evidence -> significance -> qualification; marks-proportionate density; reasoned verdict.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. The kshatrapa system was a flexible form of delegated regional rule that enabled expansion but encouraged autonomy.
2. Evidence target: 4 named units.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Listing evidence without stating what it proves.

CORRECT: Interpret and qualify every named unit.

MAINS ANGLE

Its significance lies in the trade-off between low-cost imperial reach and centrifugal regional power.

STUDY LINK

Topic 16 original solved Mains bank.

HIGH**Mains 15M-1 - Kushana imperial structure****15 marks GS-I**
Ancient History**NEWS TRIGGER**

Analyse the formation and structure of the Kushana Empire as a transregional polity. (15 marks, 250 words)

STATIC THEORY

- QUESTION: Analyse the formation and structure of the Kushana Empire as a transregional polity. (15 marks, 250 words)
- DIRECT THESIS: Kushana power emerged through staged Yuezhi migration, Bactrian consolidation and a tiered network across Central and South Asia.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 1 - CLAIM/NAMED EVIDENCE: Qian Hanshu/Hou Hanshu describe Yuezhi displacement; Khalchayan and Takht-e-Sangin support the Central Asian phase.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 1 - SIGNIFICANCE: The textual witness preserves intellectual memory, external chronology or a perspective missing from material evidence.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 1 - LIMIT: Genre, redaction, translation, distance and authorial purpose limit literal event reconstruction.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 2 - CLAIM/NAMED EVIDENCE: Kujula Kadphises unified the Guishuang branch and issued coins south of the Hindu Kush.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 2 - SIGNIFICANCE: Numismatic form, legend and metal make authority or exchange materially testable.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 2 - LIMIT: Coin imagery does not automatically reveal personal belief, and circulation does not equal a political frontier.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 3 - CLAIM/NAMED EVIDENCE: Vima Kadphises' gold/bronze coinage marks expanded monetary and ideological capacity.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 3 - SIGNIFICANCE: Numismatic form, legend and metal make authority or exchange materially testable.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 3 - LIMIT: Coin imagery does not automatically reveal personal belief, and circulation does not equal a political frontier.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 4 - CLAIM/NAMED EVIDENCE: Rabatak supplies genealogy, Bactrian royal theology and an eastern city list, though its universal claim is rhetorical.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 4 - SIGNIFICANCE: A named and locatable inscription gives a stronger chronological or ideological anchor than a free-floating tradition.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 4 - LIMIT: Epigraphs remain selective; prashasti, damaged readings and universalising claims require corroboration.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 5 - CLAIM/NAMED EVIDENCE: Bactria, Purushapura and Mathura acted as major centres rather than a single capital hierarchy.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 5 - SIGNIFICANCE: Material, workshop and iconographic evidence identifies a regional practice and its patronage context.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 5 - LIMIT: Style cannot identify an artist's ethnicity or settle priority, belief and political control by itself.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 6 - CLAIM/NAMED EVIDENCE: Kshatrapas and tribute-paying subordinates produced different tiers of control.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 6 - SIGNIFICANCE: Titulature and hierarchy expose how sovereignty, delegation and royal ideology were organised.

- EVIDENCE UNIT 6 - LIMIT: A shared title is not a complete constitution, and actual powers varied by ruler, place and time.
- BALANCE/SOURCE CRITICISM: Coin finds at distant sites cannot independently establish annexation, and chronology after Kujula remains debated.
- REASONED CONCLUSION: The empire's strength came from connecting nodes; the same delegated structure made regional fragmentation possible.
- WHY THIS EARNS MARKS: Directive fidelity; claim -> named evidence -> significance -> qualification; marks-proportionate density; reasoned verdict.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Kushana power emerged through staged Yuezhi migration, Bactrian consolidation and a tiered network across Central and South Asia.
2. Evidence target: 6 named units.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Listing evidence without stating what it proves.

CORRECT: Interpret and qualify every named unit.

MAINS ANGLE

The empire's strength came from connecting nodes; the same delegated structure made regional fragmentation possible.

STUDY LINK

Topic 16 original solved Mains bank.

HIGH**Mains 15M-2 - Coins and royal ideology**

15 marks GS-I
Ancient History

NEWS TRIGGER

How do Indo-Greek and Kushana coins illuminate political authority and cultural interaction? (15 marks, 250 words)

STATIC THEORY

- QUESTION: How do Indo-Greek and Kushana coins illuminate political authority and cultural interaction? (15 marks, 250 words)
- DIRECT THESIS: Coins were simultaneously money, royal portrait, multilingual proclamation and religious map.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 1 - CLAIM/NAMED EVIDENCE: Indo-Greek portraits and ruler names make kings attributable unlike early punch-marked coins.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 1 - SIGNIFICANCE: Numismatic form, legend and metal make authority or exchange materially testable.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 1 - LIMIT: Coin imagery does not automatically reveal personal belief, and circulation does not equal a political frontier.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 2 - CLAIM/NAMED EVIDENCE: Greek-Kharoshthi/Brahmi legends adapted authority to different users and weight standards.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 2 - SIGNIFICANCE: The named unit anchors one required dimension of the answer in precise historical evidence.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 2 - LIMIT: Its reach must remain bounded by date, region, source class and the uncertainty of reconstruction.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 3 - CLAIM/NAMED EVIDENCE: Agathocles' Balarama-Vasudeva type shows royal recognition of Indian cults within Greek engraving conventions.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 3 - SIGNIFICANCE: The named unit anchors one required dimension of the answer in precise historical evidence.

- EVIDENCE UNIT 3 - LIMIT: Its reach must remain bounded by date, region, source class and the uncertainty of reconstruction.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 4 - CLAIM/NAMED EVIDENCE: Vima's Shiva-linked types combine trident, bull and syncretic attributes.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 4 - SIGNIFICANCE: The named unit anchors one required dimension of the answer in precise historical evidence.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 4 - LIMIT: Its reach must remain bounded by date, region, source class and the uncertainty of reconstruction.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 5 - CLAIM/NAMED EVIDENCE: Kanishka/Huvishka types name Buddha, Shiva/Oesho, Nana, Mithra, Atash, Helios and Selene.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 5 - SIGNIFICANCE: The named unit anchors one required dimension of the answer in precise historical evidence.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 5 - LIMIT: Its reach must remain bounded by date, region, source class and the uncertainty of reconstruction.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 6 - CLAIM/NAMED EVIDENCE: Kushana titles and halo/flame imagery projected divine or divinely connected kingship.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 6 - SIGNIFICANCE: Titulature and hierarchy expose how sovereignty, delegation and royal ideology were organised.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 6 - LIMIT: A shared title is not a complete constitution, and actual powers varied by ruler, place and time.
- BALANCE/SOURCE CRITICISM: A coin deity is not proof of personal conversion, and circulation does not equal direct rule.
- REASONED CONCLUSION: Numismatics reveals negotiated sovereignty precisely when legend, image, metal and find-context are read together.
- WHY THIS EARNS MARKS: Directive fidelity; claim -> named evidence -> significance -> qualification; marks-proportionate density; reasoned verdict.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Coins were simultaneously money, royal portrait, multilingual proclamation and religious map.
2. Evidence target: 6 named units.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Listing evidence without stating what it proves.

CORRECT: Interpret and qualify every named unit.

MAINS ANGLE

Numismatics reveals negotiated sovereignty precisely when legend, image, metal and find-context are read together.

STUDY LINK

Topic 16 original solved Mains bank.

HIGH**Mains 15M-3 - Gandhara and Mathura**

15 marks GS-I
Ancient History

NEWS TRIGGER

Compare Gandhara and Mathura as interacting but distinct centres of early historic sculpture. (15 marks, 250 words)

STATIC THEORY

- QUESTION: Compare Gandhara and Mathura as interacting but distinct centres of early historic sculpture. (15 marks, 250 words)

- DIRECT THESIS: Both served Kushana-age devotional change, but differed in materials, workshop ancestry, visual idiom and religious range.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 1 - CLAIM/NAMED EVIDENCE: Gandhara used schist/grey stone and stucco, with Hellenised anatomy, wavy hair and heavy drapery.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 1 - SIGNIFICANCE: Material, workshop and iconographic evidence identifies a regional practice and its patronage context.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 1 - LIMIT: Style cannot identify an artist's ethnicity or settle priority, belief and political control by itself.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 2 - CLAIM/NAMED EVIDENCE: Its Buddhist programme included Buddha, bodhisattvas, life scenes and Hariti-Panchika under frontier patronage.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 2 - SIGNIFICANCE: Titulature and hierarchy expose how sovereignty, delegation and royal ideology were organised.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 2 - LIMIT: A shared title is not a complete constitution, and actual powers varied by ruler, place and time.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 3 - CLAIM/NAMED EVIDENCE: Mathura used mottled red sandstone and drew on older yaksha and local workshop traditions.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 3 - SIGNIFICANCE: The textual witness preserves intellectual memory, external chronology or a perspective missing from material evidence.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 3 - LIMIT: Genre, redaction, translation, distance and authorial purpose limit literal event reconstruction.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 4 - CLAIM/NAMED EVIDENCE: Mathura served Buddhist, Jaina, Vaishnava, Shaiva and royal patrons, including the Kanishka statue and Mat devakula.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 4 - SIGNIFICANCE: Material, workshop and iconographic evidence identifies a regional practice and its patronage context.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 4 - LIMIT: Style cannot identify an artist's ethnicity or settle priority, belief and political control by itself.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 5 - CLAIM/NAMED EVIDENCE: Sanghol's Mathura-school sculptures show object/workshop circulation beyond the city.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 5 - SIGNIFICANCE: Material, workshop and iconographic evidence identifies a regional practice and its patronage context.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 5 - LIMIT: Style cannot identify an artist's ethnicity or settle priority, belief and political control by itself.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 6 - CLAIM/NAMED EVIDENCE: Both centres participated in Buddha-image development, but priority and direct borrowing remain debated.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 6 - SIGNIFICANCE: Material, workshop and iconographic evidence identifies a regional practice and its patronage context.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 6 - LIMIT: Style cannot identify an artist's ethnicity or settle priority, belief and political control by itself.
- BALANCE/SOURCE CRITICISM: Gandhara is not pure Greek art and Mathura is not an isolated, untouched indigenous essence.
- REASONED CONCLUSION: Their comparison demonstrates parallel regional creativity within shared networks rather than a donor-copy relationship.
- WHY THIS EARNS MARKS: Directive fidelity; claim -> named evidence -> significance -> qualification; marks-proportionate density; reasoned verdict.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Both served Kushana-age devotional change, but differed in materials, workshop ancestry, visual idiom and religious range.
2. Evidence target: 6 named units.

UPSC TRAPS

- WRONG:** Listing evidence without stating what it proves.
- CORRECT:** Interpret and qualify every named unit.

MAINS ANGLE

Their comparison demonstrates parallel regional creativity within shared networks rather than a donor-copy relationship.

STUDY LINK

Topic 16 original solved Mains bank.

HIGH**Mains 20M-1 - Central Asian contacts and transformation**

20 marks GS-I
Ancient History

NEWS TRIGGER

Central Asian contacts transformed post-Mauryan India far beyond the political sphere. Critically examine. (20 marks, 250 words)

STATIC THEORY

- QUESTION: Central Asian contacts transformed post-Mauryan India far beyond the political sphere. Critically examine. (20 marks, 250 words)
- DIRECT THESIS: The transformation was substantial in coinage, networks, religion, art and kingship, but uneven and mediated by existing Indian institutions.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 1 - CLAIM/NAMED EVIDENCE: Indo-Greek portrait/bilingual coinage improved ruler attribution and political communication.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 1 - SIGNIFICANCE: Numismatic form, legend and metal make authority or exchange materially testable.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 1 - LIMIT: Coin imagery does not automatically reveal personal belief, and circulation does not equal a political frontier.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 2 - CLAIM/NAMED EVIDENCE: Shaka kshatrapas adapted delegated government; Junagadh links public works, Sanskrit and regional legitimacy.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 2 - SIGNIFICANCE: A named and locatable inscription gives a stronger chronological or ideological anchor than a free-floating tradition.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 2 - LIMIT: Epigraphs remain selective; prashasti, damaged readings and universalising claims require corroboration.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 3 - CLAIM/NAMED EVIDENCE: Kushana Bactria-Purushapura-Mathura networks joined overland and Indian circuits without uniform control.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 3 - SIGNIFICANCE: Material, workshop and iconographic evidence identifies a regional practice and its patronage context.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 3 - LIMIT: Style cannot identify an artist's ethnicity or settle priority, belief and political control by itself.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 4 - CLAIM/NAMED EVIDENCE: Kushana gold, western-Kshatrappa silver and guild endowments supported selected monetised urban sectors.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 4 - SIGNIFICANCE: Numismatic form, legend and metal make authority or exchange materially testable.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 4 - LIMIT: Coin imagery does not automatically reveal personal belief, and circulation does not equal a political frontier.

- EVIDENCE UNIT 5 - CLAIM/NAMED EVIDENCE: Heliodorus, Agathocles types and plural Kushana coins show religious adaptation across cults.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 5 - SIGNIFICANCE: Numismatic form, legend and metal make authority or exchange materially testable.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 5 - LIMIT: Coin imagery does not automatically reveal personal belief, and circulation does not equal a political frontier.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 6 - CLAIM/NAMED EVIDENCE: Kanishka patronage and merchant-monastic routes aided Buddhist transmission into Central Asia.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 6 - SIGNIFICANCE: The evidence connects political geography to institutions of exchange, mobility and patronage.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 6 - LIMIT: The surviving record is urban and elite-heavy; scale and prosperity cannot be generalised to every region or household.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 7 - CLAIM/NAMED EVIDENCE: Gandhara and Mathura demonstrate layered artistic innovation rather than simple import.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 7 - SIGNIFICANCE: Material, workshop and iconographic evidence identifies a regional practice and its patronage context.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 7 - LIMIT: Style cannot identify an artist's ethnicity or settle priority, belief and political control by itself.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 8 - CLAIM/NAMED EVIDENCE: Greek astral vocabulary and multilingual inscriptions reveal selective knowledge and language exchange.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 8 - SIGNIFICANCE: A named and locatable inscription gives a stronger chronological or ideological anchor than a free-floating tradition.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 8 - LIMIT: Epigraphs remain selective; prashasti, damaged readings and universalising claims require corroboration.
- BALANCE/SOURCE CRITICISM: The archive is elite-heavy; rural life, lower social groups and regional non-participants are less visible, while conflict accompanied synthesis.
- REASONED CONCLUSION: The period is best called reciprocal but unequal transformation, not foreign domination followed by passive absorption.
- WHY THIS EARNS MARKS: Directive fidelity; claim -> named evidence -> significance -> qualification; marks-proportionate density; reasoned verdict.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. The transformation was substantial in coinage, networks, religion, art and kingship, but uneven and mediated by existing Indian institutions.
2. Evidence target: 8 named units.

UPSC TRAPS

- WRONG:** Listing evidence without stating what it proves.
- CORRECT:** Interpret and qualify every named unit.

MAINS ANGLE

The period is best called reciprocal but unequal transformation, not foreign domination followed by passive absorption.

STUDY LINK

Topic 16 original solved Mains bank.

HIGH

Mains 20M-2 - Kushana cosmopolitanism20 marks GS-I
Ancient History**NEWS TRIGGER**

Evaluate the nature and limits of Kushana cosmopolitanism. (20 marks, 250 words)

STATIC THEORY

- QUESTION: Evaluate the nature and limits of Kushana cosmopolitanism. (20 marks, 250 words)
- DIRECT THESIS: Kushana cosmopolitanism was an imperial strategy rooted in transregional geography, multilingual media and plural patronage, not a borderless social equality.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 1 - CLAIM/NAMED EVIDENCE: Yuezhi-Bactrian origins and Chinese textual links place the dynasty inside wider Asian history.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 1 - SIGNIFICANCE: The textual witness preserves intellectual memory, external chronology or a perspective missing from material evidence.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 1 - LIMIT: Genre, redaction, translation, distance and authorial purpose limit literal event reconstruction.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 2 - CLAIM/NAMED EVIDENCE: Rabatak's Bactrian-Greek script and Nana-centred royal theology join Iranian, Hellenistic and local idioms.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 2 - SIGNIFICANCE: A named and locatable inscription gives a stronger chronological or ideological anchor than a free-floating tradition.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 2 - LIMIT: Epigraphs remain selective; prashasti, damaged readings and universalising claims require corroboration.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 3 - CLAIM/NAMED EVIDENCE: Coins moved from Greek to Bactrian legends and displayed Indian, Iranian and Greek deities.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 3 - SIGNIFICANCE: Numismatic form, legend and metal make authority or exchange materially testable.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 3 - LIMIT: Coin imagery does not automatically reveal personal belief, and circulation does not equal a political frontier.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 4 - CLAIM/NAMED EVIDENCE: Purushapura and Mathura linked Buddhist, royal and urban patronage across distinct regions.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 4 - SIGNIFICANCE: Material, workshop and iconographic evidence identifies a regional practice and its patronage context.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 4 - LIMIT: Style cannot identify an artist's ethnicity or settle priority, belief and political control by itself.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 5 - CLAIM/NAMED EVIDENCE: Silk-route and lower-Indus positioning connected caravan and maritime exchange.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 5 - SIGNIFICANCE: The evidence connects political geography to institutions of exchange, mobility and patronage.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 5 - LIMIT: The surviving record is urban and elite-heavy; scale and prosperity cannot be generalised to every region or household.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 6 - CLAIM/NAMED EVIDENCE: Buddhist missions and Gandhara imagery travelled toward Central and East Asia.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 6 - SIGNIFICANCE: Material, workshop and iconographic evidence identifies a regional practice and its patronage context.

- EVIDENCE UNIT 6 - LIMIT: Style cannot identify an artist's ethnicity or settle priority, belief and political control by itself.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 7 - CLAIM/NAMED EVIDENCE: Mat and Surkh Kotal royal images created a transregional language of sacral kingship.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 7 - SIGNIFICANCE: The named unit anchors one required dimension of the answer in precise historical evidence.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 7 - LIMIT: Its reach must remain bounded by date, region, source class and the uncertainty of reconstruction.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 8 - CLAIM/NAMED EVIDENCE: Guild endowments and local cults show cosmopolitan rule operating through regional institutions.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 8 - SIGNIFICANCE: The evidence connects political geography to institutions of exchange, mobility and patronage.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 8 - LIMIT: The surviving record is urban and elite-heavy; scale and prosperity cannot be generalised to every region or household.
- BALANCE/SOURCE CRITICISM: Direct rule was tiered, coin circulation uneven, and elite cultural plurality says little about equality or everyday bilingualism.
- REASONED CONCLUSION: Cosmopolitanism describes connected repertoires and audiences; its political foundation remained conquest, hierarchy and selective access.
- WHY THIS EARNS MARKS: Directive fidelity; claim -> named evidence -> significance -> qualification; marks-proportionate density; reasoned verdict.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Kushana cosmopolitanism was an imperial strategy rooted in transregional geography, multilingual media and plural patronage, not a borderless social equality.
2. Evidence target: 8 named units.

UPSC TRAPS

- WRONG:** Listing evidence without stating what it proves.
- CORRECT:** Interpret and qualify every named unit.

MAINS ANGLE

Cosmopolitanism describes connected repertoires and audiences; its political foundation remained conquest, hierarchy and selective access.

STUDY LINK

Topic 16 original solved Mains bank.

HIGH**Mains 20M-3 - Source criticism and chronology**

20 marks GS-I
Ancient History

NEWS TRIGGER

Why are chronology and political geography of the Indo-Greeks, Shakas and Kushanas difficult to reconstruct? Discuss with sources. (20 marks, 250 words)

STATIC THEORY

- QUESTION: Why are chronology and political geography of the Indo-Greeks, Shakas and Kushanas difficult to reconstruct? Discuss with sources. (20 marks, 250 words)
- DIRECT THESIS: The difficulty arises from concurrent rulers, fragmented archives, mobile coinage, rhetorical inscriptions and later textual traditions.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 1 - CLAIM/NAMED EVIDENCE: Dozens of Bactro-Indo-Greek rulers are known only from coins; monograms and sequences remain debated.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 1 - SIGNIFICANCE: Numismatic form, legend and metal make authority or exchange materially testable.

- EVIDENCE UNIT 1 - LIMIT: Coin imagery does not automatically reveal personal belief, and circulation does not equal a political frontier.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 2 - CLAIM/NAMED EVIDENCE: Overstrikes can mean conquest, succession or metal reuse, complicating political inference.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 2 - SIGNIFICANCE: Numismatic form, legend and metal make authority or exchange materially testable.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 2 - LIMIT: Coin imagery does not automatically reveal personal belief, and circulation does not equal a political frontier.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 3 - CLAIM/NAMED EVIDENCE: Milindapanho preserves intellectual memory rather than a continuous reign narrative.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 3 - SIGNIFICANCE: The textual witness preserves intellectual memory, external chronology or a perspective missing from material evidence.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 3 - LIMIT: Genre, redaction, translation, distance and authorial purpose limit literal event reconstruction.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 4 - CLAIM/NAMED EVIDENCE: Shaka branches at Taxila, Mathura and western India overlap and use repeated kshatrapa titles.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 4 - SIGNIFICANCE: Material, workshop and iconographic evidence identifies a regional practice and its patronage context.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 4 - LIMIT: Style cannot identify an artist's ethnicity or settle priority, belief and political control by itself.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 5 - CLAIM/NAMED EVIDENCE: Azes-Vikrama and Shaka-era founder debates reveal uncertain era identification.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 5 - SIGNIFICANCE: The named unit anchors one required dimension of the answer in precise historical evidence.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 5 - LIMIT: Its reach must remain bounded by date, region, source class and the uncertainty of reconstruction.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 6 - CLAIM/NAMED EVIDENCE: Rabatak clarifies Kushana genealogy but includes disputed readings and an exaggerated whole-India claim.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 6 - SIGNIFICANCE: A named and locatable inscription gives a stronger chronological or ideological anchor than a free-floating tradition.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 6 - LIMIT: Epigraphs remain selective; prashasti, damaged readings and universalising claims require corroboration.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 7 - CLAIM/NAMED EVIDENCE: Kanishka's accession is commonly c. 127 CE, while the older 78 CE view survives.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 7 - SIGNIFICANCE: The named unit anchors one required dimension of the answer in precise historical evidence.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 7 - LIMIT: Its reach must remain bounded by date, region, source class and the uncertainty of reconstruction.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 8 - CLAIM/NAMED EVIDENCE: Chinese and classical texts use external ethnonyms and may rely on distance or hearsay.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 8 - SIGNIFICANCE: The textual witness preserves intellectual memory, external chronology or a perspective missing from material evidence.
- EVIDENCE UNIT 8 - LIMIT: Genre, redaction, translation, distance and authorial purpose limit literal event reconstruction.

- BALANCE/SOURCE CRITICISM: The archive is difficult, not unusable: convergence among dated inscriptions, die studies, archaeology and texts creates bounded conclusions.
- REASONED CONCLUSION: A defensible reconstruction therefore uses ranges, regional maps and explicit confidence levels rather than false precision.
- WHY THIS EARNS MARKS: Directive fidelity; claim -> named evidence -> significance -> qualification; marks-proportionate density; reasoned verdict.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. The difficulty arises from concurrent rulers, fragmented archives, mobile coinage, rhetorical inscriptions and later textual traditions.
2. Evidence target: 8 named units.

UPSC TRAPS

- WRONG:** Listing evidence without stating what it proves.
- CORRECT:** Interpret and qualify every named unit.

MAINS ANGLE

A defensible reconstruction therefore uses ranges, regional maps and explicit confidence levels rather than false precision.

STUDY LINK

Topic 16 original solved Mains bank.

End of Register Notes - UPSC Agent / Copilot CLI